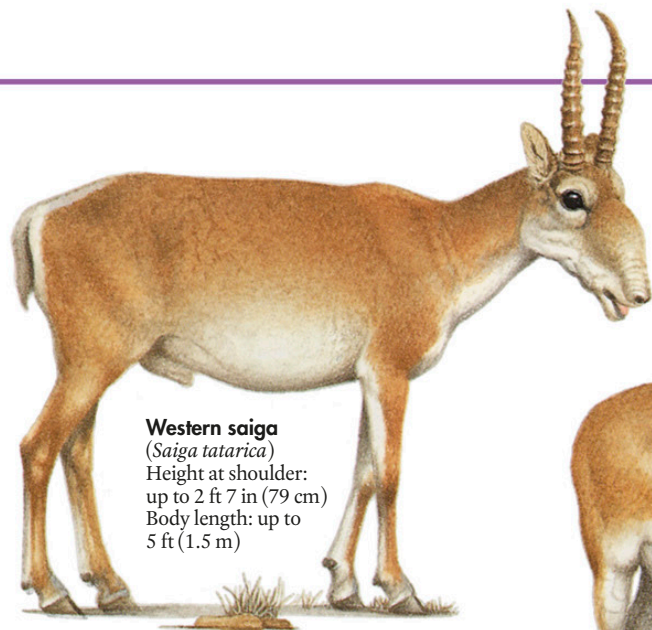




Western saiga
(*Saiga tatarica*)
Height at shoulder:
up to 2 ft 7 in (79 cm)
Body length: up to
5 ft (1.5 m)



Yarkand gazelle
(*Gazella subgutturosa*)
Height at shoulder:
up to 2 ft 4 in (70 cm)

Pallas's cat
(*Otocolobus manul*)
Body length: up to
2 ft 2 in (65 cm)
Tail: up to
12 in (31 cm)



Suede coats

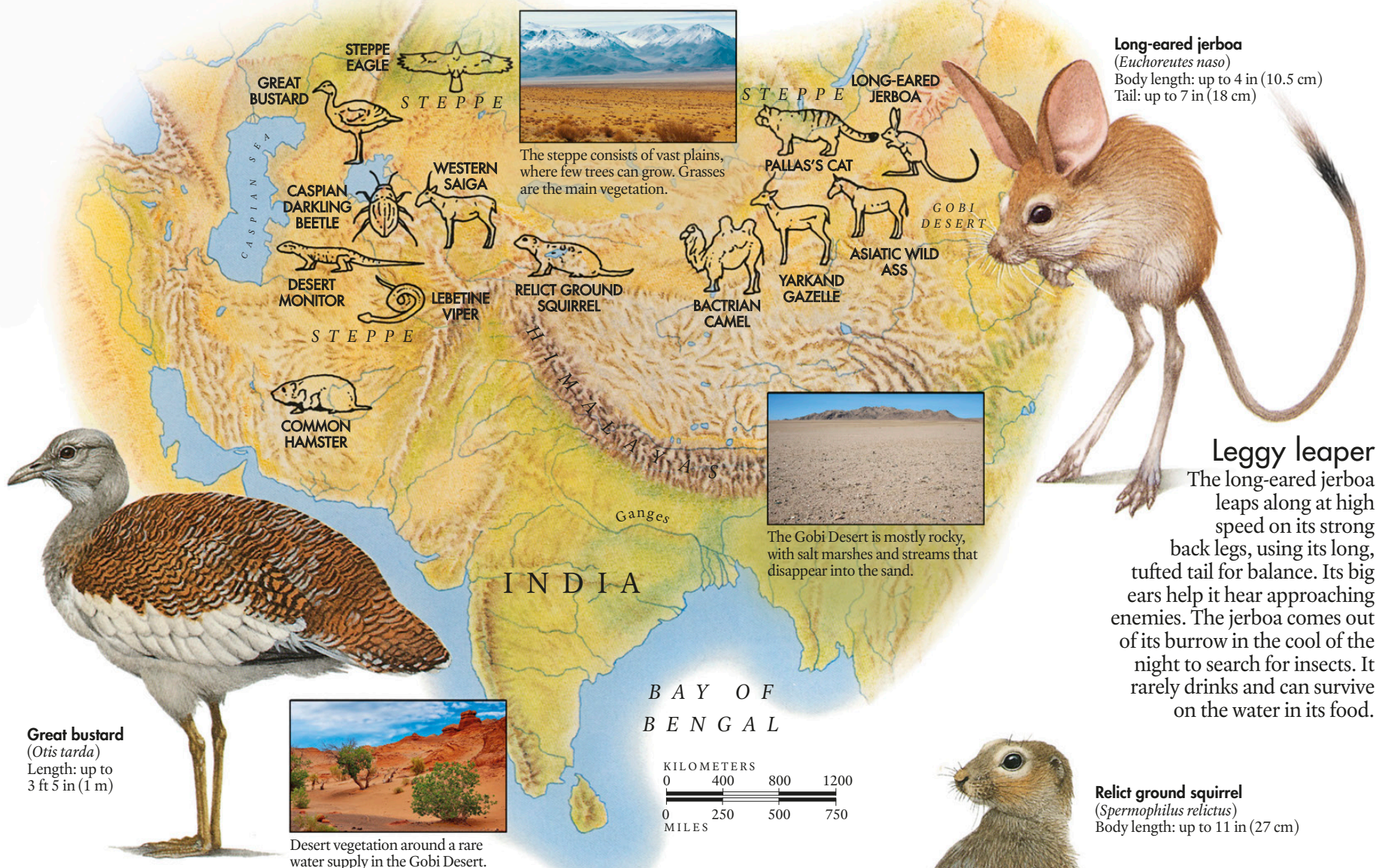
The yarkand gazelle was almost wiped out by hunters because its coat was used to make suede cloth. It is now a protected species. As it grazes, the gazelle tramples seeds into the ground, fertilizes the soil with its droppings, and clears spaces for new shoots to sprout. This helps the steppe to survive.

Filter nose

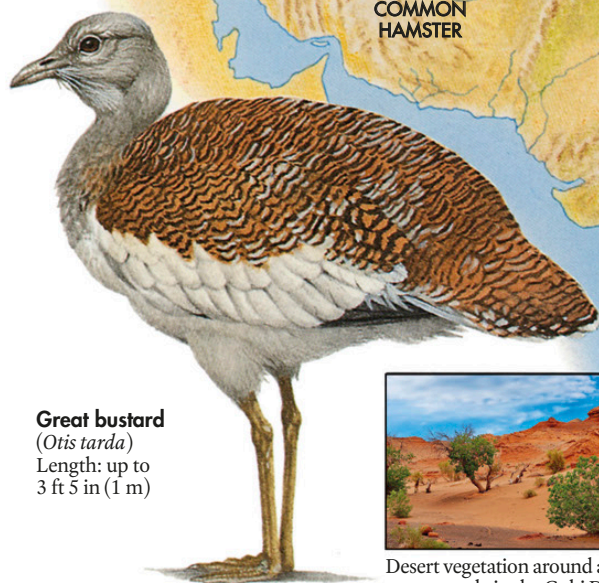
The saiga antelope has a large, trunklike nose. Its nostrils face downward and it has hairs and glands inside its nose to filter out sand and dust. Huge herds once lived on the steppe, but the male saiga's horns were used in Chinese medicine, so millions were killed. Between poaching and disease, the saiga is now critically endangered.

Furry feline

Pallas's cat has long, dense fur, especially underneath its body, which helps keep out the cold. The cat's eyes are positioned high up on its face so that when it peers over rocks to look for prey, its head won't be seen. It comes out at dawn and dusk to hunt for birds and small mammals.



Great bustard
(*Otis tarda*)
Length: up to
3 ft 5 in (1 m)



Displaying male

In spring, the male great bustard puts on a spectacular courtship display. He puffs out his neck, holds his tail over his back, and spreads out his wings to form two huge, white rosettes on the sides of his body. The great bustard is one of the largest flying birds, but it usually walks or runs.

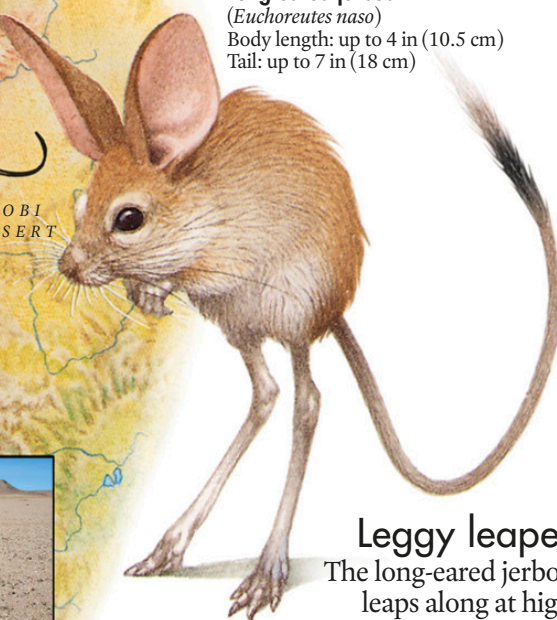


Caspian darkling beetle
(*Sternodes caspicus*)
Length: up to 1.2 in (3 cm)

Striped protection

The white stripes on the darkling beetle help break up the outline of its body so that predators cannot see it against the sand. It has a thick exoskeleton and a compact shape, which reduces water loss and helps the beetle survive the heat.

Long-eared jerboa
(*Euchoreutes naso*)
Body length: up to 4 in (10.5 cm)
Tail: up to 7 in (18 cm)



Leggy leaper

The long-eared jerboa leaps along at high speed on its strong back legs, using its long, tufted tail for balance. Its big ears help it hear approaching enemies. The jerboa comes out of its burrow in the cool of the night to search for insects. It rarely drinks and can survive on the water in its food.

Relict ground squirrel
(*Spermophilus relictus*)
Body length: up to 11 in (27 cm)



Busy burrower

The relict ground squirrel lives in underground burrows in the Tian Shan mountains of west-central Asia, on meadows up to 9,000 ft (2,800 m) in altitude. It hibernates during fall and winter, emerging in spring to breed. European and Asian ground squirrels are sometimes called susliks.